

Where do they come from?

A vast majority of the world's cyber criminals are American men. However, a few of them also reside in places like Russia, China, Nigeria and other parts of the world.

The ATM hit

On November 8, 2008, many thieves fanned out across the globe. With cloned or stolen debit cards in hand, they hit more than 2,100 money machines in at least 280 cities and in 12 hours, they walked off with more than \$9 million in cash.

Cyber Crime's Most (In)Famous

Some did it for kicks, some craved the fame, some thought they were making a political statement while others obviously went for the money. Here's a look at some of cyber crime's most infamous criminals and their hacking exploits.

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There is a very thin line that divides cyber-pranksters from cyber-criminals. Some of the most notorious cyber crimes of the last few years have been attributed to youngsters, who perhaps innocuously thought they were playing a prank when they hacked into networks or created malicious code for viruses, malware, worms or Trojans. Maybe they didn't have the intention of making a financial gain from their activities, nor did they aspire for celebrity status or they did it, purely for the heck of it and as a prank. Did they just want to prove it to themselves?

Whatever their motivation, there is a lot to learn about the psyche of a cyber criminal. Much information can be gathered by studying their profiles and understanding what they did. Without trying to glorify these deviants, they are admittedly above average intelligence.

One might even say in some cases they have a gift. Most of them have a deep understanding of the human mind and how to tempt it. How they use their gifts is under question. They're talented individuals with a tendency to walk on the wrong side of the law. Eventually many of the black-hatters do see the light and clean up their act, becoming consultants or working for big names in the tech industry.

Here is a look at some of the most colourful cyber criminals that the world has known. But of course the real geniuses are those that have never got caught. Yet...



MARK ABENE

(Born 1972)

Born in New York, he had his first contact with computers at the age of 9. It turned out to be a proverbial case of love at first sight. He literally could not keep himself away from computers and he devoted himself to learning the few popular programming languages. In the mid 1980s, he came in contact with a group of teenaged hackers that went by the name of Legion of Doom. Lurking with them he further perfected his hacking techniques. When the group disintegrated due to internal dissension, Mark Abene

shifted his loyalties to another group of local hackers, the Masters of Deception.

He had keen interest in telecommunications, and when AT&T's network crashed in January 15, 1990, US authorities held him and other members of Masters of Deception as being responsible. On January 24, 1990, Mark Abene's house was searched and in December 1991, he was formally arrested. When he was released in November 1994, he had a hero's welcome from large number of people who are interested in technology. Today he works as an independent consultant, advising corporations on matters related to cyber security.



KEVIN MITNICK

(Born 1963)

At one point of time in his career, Kevin Mitnick enjoyed the unsavoury distinction of being the most wanted cyber criminal in America. Believe it or not, his tryst with crime started when he was only 12 years old, when he cracked the punch-card system used in Los Angeles bus system to gain free rides in any bus in the greater LA area. In 1979, at the age of 16, he gained unauthorised access to the computer system of Digital Equipment Corporation (DEC), from where he copied some crucial software.

For this crime, he was convicted and sentenced to 12 months in prison and three years of probation. But the punishment did not make him change his ways.

After his release, he hacked into the systems of some schools in LA and into the one that was owned by Pacific Bell. When a warrant for his arrest was issued, he fled and became a fugitive for almost two and a half years. During his days as a fugitive, he gained further notoriety by gaining unauthorised access into many other computer systems. When he was apprehended in February 1995, many mobile phones, which he had cloned, were found with him. He was also found in possession of multiple false identities. In 1999, he was convicted and sentenced to four years of prison. These days he is running a cyber security company.